

NEXT STEP

OUR NEXT CHAPTER



The visual and verbal identity system for Next Step —
the education fair where students and universities
meet.

INTERNAL USE

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The moment before everything changes



Next Step exists for one specific moment: the weeks when a 12th grade student stops being a pupil and starts becoming whatever comes after. It is a moment of enormous possibility and almost no information.

The fair closes that gap. It brings universities, institutes, admission officers, scholarship providers and vocational programs into one room, and puts students, parents and teachers in front of them. Conversations replace guesswork. Options become decisions.

Everything in this identity is built to hold that moment steady — confident enough to be trusted by ministries and universities, warm enough to be approached by a seventeen-year-old who is not sure what to ask.

THE IDEA IN ONE LINE

A crowded hall of open doors, and someone standing beside you at every one of them.

Mission, vision, values

MISSION

To connect every graduating student with the universities, guidance and funding they need to take a confident next step.

VISION

A region where no student's future is decided by a lack of information.

VALUES

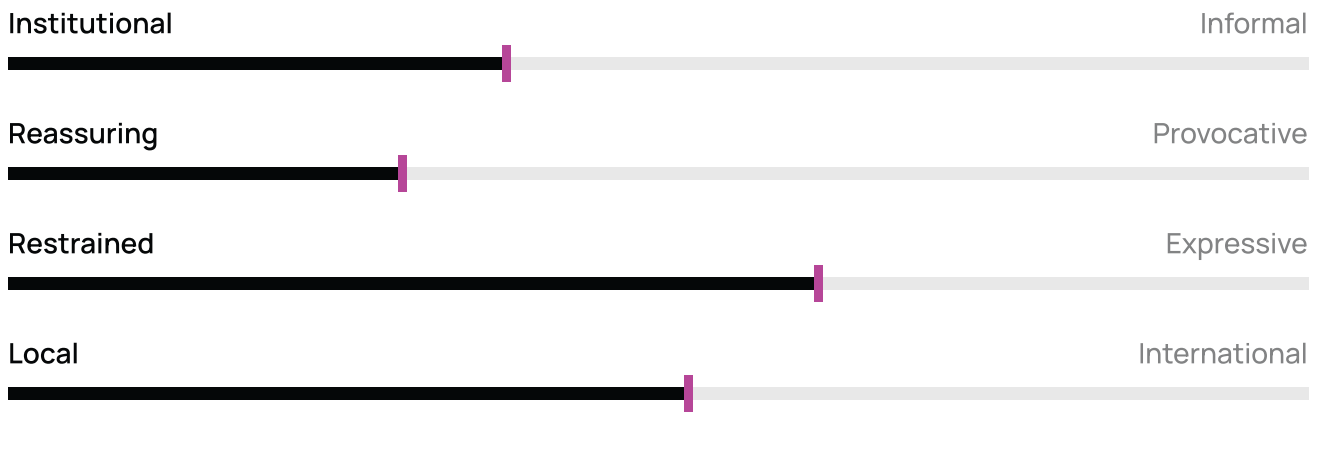
Access Every student is welcome, whatever their school, city or score.	Clarity Plain answers about admission, cost and outcomes. No brochures that hide the details.
Ambition We assume students are capable of more than they have been told.	Responsibility Education, opportunity and sustainability guide how the fair is run, not only what it says.

PILLARS

Education · Opportunity · Sustainability (EOS) – the three commitments the fair is measured against, aligned to the UN Sustainable Development Goals.

How the brand behaves

Next Step sits between two audiences with different expectations. These sliders describe where the brand should land when the two pull in opposite directions.



POSITIONING STATEMENT

For students finishing school in the Kurdistan Region and Iraq, **Next Step** is the education fair that turns a confusing admission season into a set of clear, reachable choices — because it puts universities, scholarships and honest advice in one hall, at one time, for free.

Primary lockup

The stacked wordmark with the tagline is the primary signature. Use it wherever the brand is being introduced: covers, signage, opening slides, campaign artwork.



WHY IT WORKS

Two heavy lines of type stacked into a block – a step. The cut in the final E and the magenta square break the mass, so the mark reads as movement rather than a plaque.

FILE NAMING

nextstep_primary_black.svg
nextstep_primary_white.svg
nextstep_wordmark_black.svg
nextstep_wordmark_white.svg

Always place the supplied artwork. Never re-typeset the wordmark, and never rebuild it from a font – the letterforms are customised.

Construction



1 Wordmark

NEXT over STEP, optically aligned to a common left and right edge. The two words are the same width; this is the block that gives the mark its weight.

2 The Step

The magenta square sitting in the counter of the E. It is the only colour in the mark and the seed of every graphic element in the system.

3 The cut E

The final E is drawn as three separated bars. The gaps read as forward motion and are never closed up or re-spaced.

4 Tagline

OUR NEXT CHAPTER, set in light letter-spaced caps in magenta, centred under the block. It is a permanent part of the primary lockup.

Variations & lockups

Four approved versions. Choose by background, not by preference.



PRIMARY — ONE COLOUR

Full ink. Default for print, documents and any single-colour reproduction.



REVERSED

White on ink, magenta or cobalt. Never on a mid-tone or a busy photograph.



WORDMARK — NO TAGLINE

For small sizes, app icons, badges, merchandise and repeat use inside a document.



MAGENTA WORDMARK

Restricted use: campaign artwork on Bone or white only. Not for partner documents.

A horizontal lockup does not exist. Where width is the only option, use the wordmark and set the tagline separately as typography, following the type rules on page 15.

Clear space & minimum size

Clear space is measured in **X** — the height of the magenta square. Keep a minimum of 1X free on every side. No type, image edge, partner logo or fold may enter it.



MINIMUM SIZES

Primary lockup, print	28 mm wide
Primary lockup, screen	120 px wide
Wordmark, print	18 mm wide
Wordmark, screen	72 px wide

BELOW MINIMUM



Under these sizes the tagline and the cut E fill in. Switch to the wordmark before you scale further down.

What never happens

Each example below has been rejected. If a layout requires one of these, change the layout.



✗ Stretched or condensed



✗ Rotated or tilted



✗ On a gradient or low-contrast fill



✗ Recoloured outside the palette



✗ Shadows, glows, bevels or outlines



✗ Crowded – clear space broken

Also never: placing the mark inside another shape, adding a container box, locking it to a partner logo without a divider, or setting the tagline in a different typeface.

When co-branding, separate logos with a 1px ink rule and match optical height, not bounding-box height.

Primary palette

Two colours carry the brand: Next Ink and Step Magenta. They come directly from the logo and appear on everything.

Next Ink

HEX #050708

RGB 5 7 8

CMYK 75 68 67 90

PANTONE Neutral Black C

Step Magenta

HEX #B64698

RGB 182 70 152

CMYK 30 88 3 0

PANTONE 247 C (near)

Bone

HEX #F4F1EE

RGB 244 241

238

CMYK 3 3 4 0

Paper & panel

base

NEXT INK

Type, the logo, backgrounds for hero moments. It is a near-black, not pure black — it stays warm on screen and prints richer.

STEP MAGENTA

The accent of arrival: the one thing you want a student to notice. Highlights, calls to action, the graphic square.

BONE

Quiet ground for long text, tables and panels. Use instead of grey boxes.

Secondary & extended

Magenta alone cannot carry a three-day fair with dozens of tracks, partners and signs. **Next Cobalt** is the secondary colour: it sits opposite magenta, reads as institutional and trustworthy, and gives the system a second voice for wayfinding, data and partner-facing material.

SECONDARY Next Cobalt HEX #2C4BE0 RGB 44 75 224 CMYK 84 70 0 0 PANTONE 2728 C (near)	Signal Amber #F2A93B · 242 169 59	Slate #4A4B4D · 74 75 77
	Deep Teal #0E9B94 · 14 155 148	Grey #828384 · 130 131 132

Cobalt — where it goes

Wayfinding and floor plans, seminar and agenda material, partner and university documents, diagrams, links and interactive states.

Slate & Grey — structure

Secondary text, rules, table lines, captions and disabled states.

Amber & Teal — support only

Category coding inside charts, schedules and zone maps. Never as a page background and never near the logo.

The hard rule

Magenta and cobalt never touch as adjacent large areas. Separate them with ink, white or Bone.

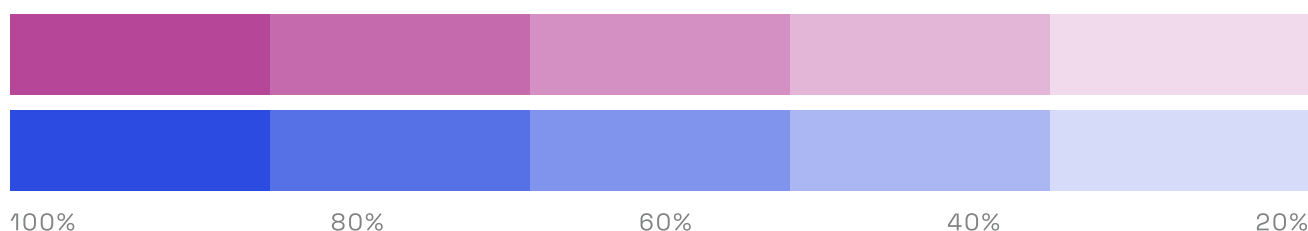
Ratios, tints & contrast

DISTRIBUTION ACROSS ANY LAYOUT



Magenta is an accent, not a field. If a page looks pink from across the room, cut it back.

TINTS — FOR CHARTS AND PANELS ONLY



CONTRAST — WCAG 2.1 AGAINST WHITE

COLOUR	RATIO	BODY TEXT	NOTES
Next Ink	19.9:1	AAA	Default text colour
Step Magenta	4.9:1	AA	Body text OK; not for text under 14px on tinted grounds
Next Cobalt	6.6:1	AA	Safe for links and small type
Signal Amber	2.0:1	Fail	Fills and ink-backed type only, never text on white
Grey #828384	3.9:1	Large only	Captions at 18px+ or use Slate instead

Two typefaces

Space Grotesk Display & headlines

400 / 500 / 600 / 700

A B C D E F G H I J K L M
N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz 0123456789 &?!

Chosen because its flat terminals and squared curves echo the logo's letterforms.
Use it for headlines, numbers, labels and anything set in caps.

Manrope Text & interface

400 / 500 / 600 / 700 / 800

A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz 0123456789 &?!

Open, unfussy and legible at small sizes and long lengths. Use it for all body copy, forms, tables, captions and web interface.

Both are open-source and free for commercial use, available from Google Fonts. System fallback where neither can be embedded: Arial for text, Arial Black for display. No third typeface enters the system.

Scale, hierarchy & rules

DISPLAY	Take your next step	Grotesk 700 / 96–180px / –2.5%
H1	Universities and institutes	Grotesk 700 / 40–56px
H2	Seminars and panel discussions	Grotesk 600 / 28–32px
H3	Registration & welcome remarks	Manrope 700 / 20–22px
BODY	Meet admission representatives and get personalised advice on applications, scholarships and financial support.	Manrope 400 / 16–18px / 1.6
LABEL	DAY 2 • HALL A	Grotesk 600 / 12–14px / +20%
CAPTION	Cultural Factory, Sulaimani · 10:00–20:00	Manrope 500 / 13–14px

Alignment. Flush left, ragged right. Centred type only in the logo lockup and on signage headers.

Case. Sentence case for headlines and body. All-caps only for labels, at 12px+ with +20% tracking.

Emphasis. Weight or magenta, never both. No italics, no underlines except real links.

Measure. 55–75 characters per line. Break to columns rather than running wider.

Minimums. Never below 12pt in print or 14px on screen. Forms and signage never below 16px.

Tagline as type. Grotesk 500, all caps, +25% tracking, magenta. Nothing else.

The Step

One element, taken from the logo: a solid rectangle with a 1:0.3 ratio.

Repeated, offset or stacked, it becomes rules, bars, dividers, patterns and progress. Nothing else is invented.

ASCENDING STEPS



CUT BARS



STEP GRID PATTERN



REVERSED FIELD



Angles. 0° and 90° only. The system has no diagonals, arcs or rounded corners.

Colour. One accent per composition. Magenta or cobalt, not both in the same pattern.

Density. Patterns stay under a third of any surface, and never sit behind body text.

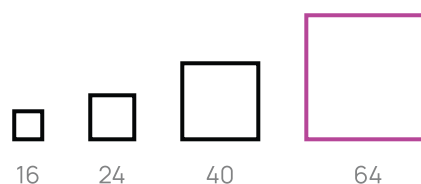
Icons

Icons are drawn, not decorated: flat line, single weight, square ends, built on a 24px grid. They label things in a hall full of people who are looking for a room, a desk or a time.

SPECIFICATION

Grid	24 × 24 px
Stroke	2 px, no taper
Caps & joins	Butt / miter
Corner radius	0
Padding	2 px live area inset
Colour	Ink, white or one accent

SIZES IN USE



Scale in whole steps only, and re-draw rather than scale below 16px. Signage icons start at 64px.

Do

Keep one concept per icon. Use the accent for a single detail – a highlighted square, a filled counter – not the whole glyph.

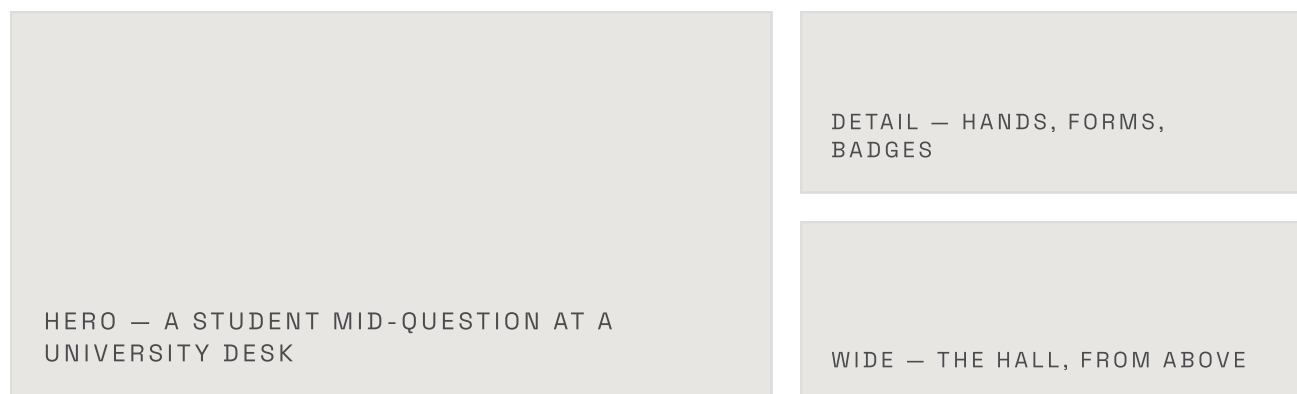
Don't

No filled or duotone sets, no perspective, no gradients, no emoji standing in for an icon, no mixing icon libraries.

A base set covering venue, agenda, university, scholarship, workshop, registration and accessibility is drawn on request – icons are commissioned, not sourced.

Photography direction

Photograph the conversation, not the room. Real students, real desks, available light. No stock, no staged handshakes, no empty halls.



Grey frames are placeholders. Supply photography and these become the approved reference set.

Subject

Students first, then the people advising them. Eye level, waist-up or closer. Faces visible and unposed.

Framing

Square-on and level. Crop to the grid columns, full-bleed or a clean rectangle — never a rounded or shaped mask.

Consent

Written release for every identifiable minor before publication. No exceptions for social.

Light & colour

Daylight or venue light. Neutral white balance, no filters, no heavy grading. Let brand colour come from the graphics, not the photo.

Type over image

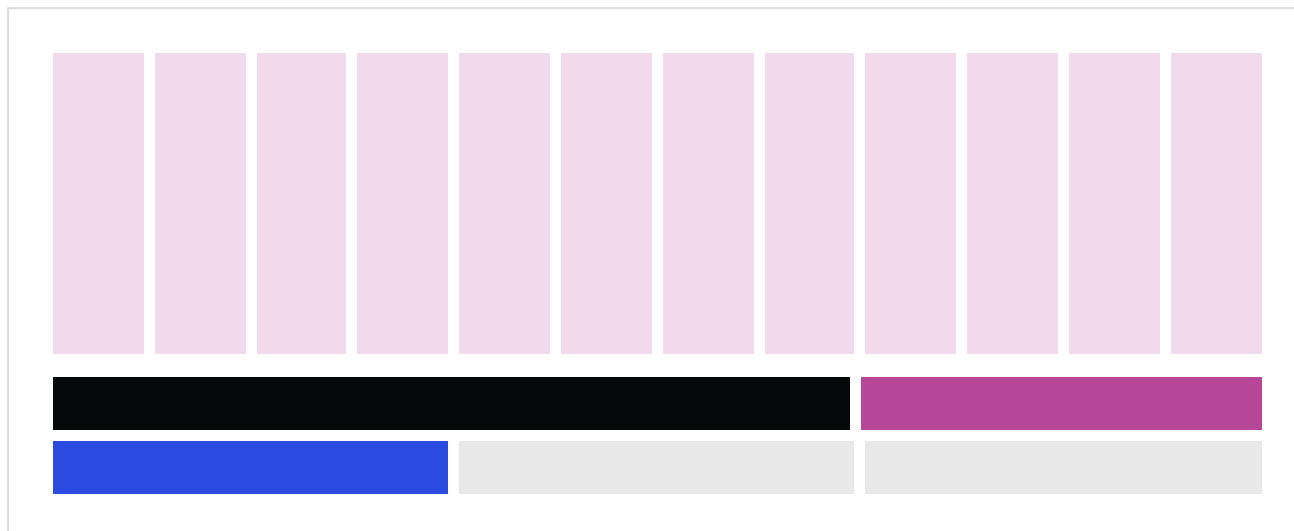
Only on an ink panel or a solid bar, never directly on the photo. Minimum 60% coverage behind the type.

Avoid

Stock imagery, graduation caps thrown in the air, ladders and staircases as metaphors, flare, tilted horizons.

Layout grid

A 12-column grid on every format, with an 8px spacing scale. Elements align to columns and to the baseline; nothing floats.



MARGINS & GUTTERS

A4 / Letter document	18 mm / 5 mm
Poster & banner	4% / 1.5%
Desktop web (1440)	80 px / 24 px
Mobile (375)	20 px / 16 px, 4 col

SPACING SCALE (PX)

8	16	24	32	48	64
96	128				

Use adjacent values for related elements and skip two steps to separate sections.

Anchor left. Headlines start at column 1. Long copy runs 6–8 columns wide.

One idea per band. Divide pages into full-width horizontal bands, not floating cards.

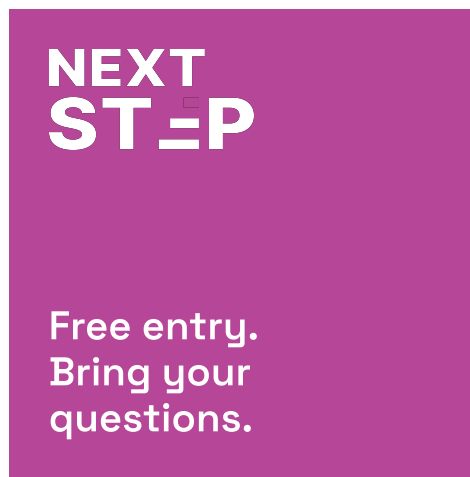
Corners are square. Radius 0 everywhere, including buttons, inputs and images.

Social & digital

Most students meet the brand on a phone. Every post carries the wordmark, one message and one accent.



FEED POST 1:1



ACCENT POST 1:1



STORY 9:16

Avatar

The wordmark, white on ink, centred with 1X clear space. Square avatars are never cropped from the full lockup.

Web & buttons

Ink or magenta fill, white label, radius 0, minimum 48px tall. Focus state: 2px cobalt outline, 2px offset.

Safe areas

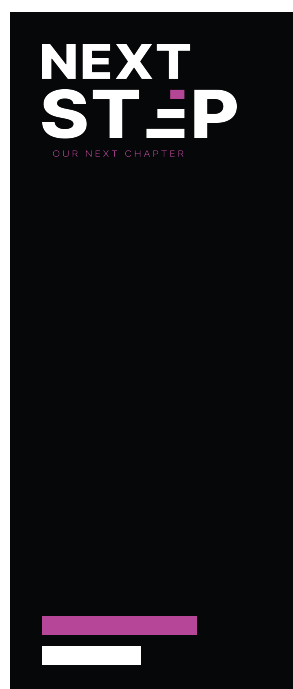
Keep type 14% clear of the top and bottom of stories and reels. Never place the logo where a platform overlays its UI.

Motion

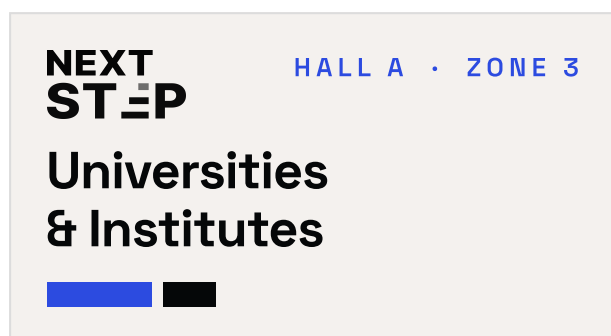
Elements step in — hard cuts or short 180ms slides on one axis. No fades over 250ms, no bounce, no parallax.

Signage & event

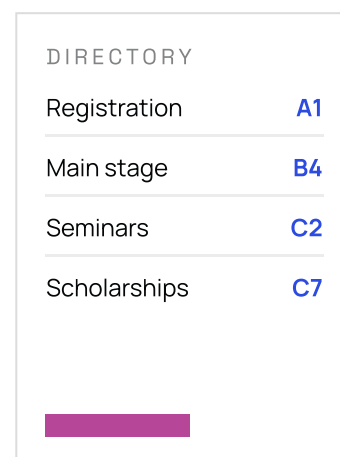
In the venue the brand's job is orientation. Ink for structure, cobalt for wayfinding, magenta for the moments that matter: entrance, stage, registration.



ROLL-UP BANNER



ZONE HEADER / BOOTH FASCIA



WAYFINDING PANEL

Legibility distances

Cap height 25 mm per 10 m of reading distance. Zone headers 120 mm minimum; directory text 20 mm minimum.

Materials

Matte finishes only. Reusable and recyclable substrates first; no dated print on anything that could be used again next edition.

Colour coding

One colour per zone, drawn from cobalt, teal, amber and slate. Magenta is never a zone colour — it marks the brand, not a place.

Accessibility

Never colour alone: pair every zone colour with a letter and an icon. Mount panels at 1.4–1.6 m centre height.

Voice & tone

Write the way a good advisor talks: direct, specific, never condescending. Assume the reader is seventeen, intelligent, and short on time.

WE SAY

Free entry. Bring your grades and your questions.

NOT

Embark on a transformative journey towards your educational destiny.

WE SAY

32 universities and institutes. Three days. One hall.

NOT

A wide array of leading institutions from across the region and beyond.

WE SAY

Not sure what to study? Talk to someone who has done it.

NOT

Unlock your potential and discover the possibilities that await you.

Rules

Short sentences. Active voice. Numbers as numerals. Name the thing — the university, the deadline, the hall. Cut every adjective you can lose.

Naming

Next Step in body copy after first mention;

Next Step Fair in formal, partner and official contexts. Never NSF, never Nextstep.

Never

Journey, unlock, empower, dream big, limitless, game-changing. No exclamation marks in headlines. No promises about admission we cannot keep.

Tagline

Our Next Chapter is permanent and set only as part of the lockup or per the type rule on page 15. It is never rewritten per edition.

Questions about applying the brand, or a case not covered here? Ask before you improvise.

**NEXT
STEP**